PHOTOGRAPHS BY STEVE FEARNLY

In the workshop with... Steve Fearnley

We find out about the Yorkshire-based woodturner

Steve Fearnley has been woodturning for some years now, since 2009. Steve produces a variety of items ranging from household goods and ornaments to clocks and trophies. He also runs his own website; www.oldfern.co.uk.

How, when and why did you start turning?

I had been making trophies for a couple of years for the school I worked at and thought I could do a better job with a lathe. My dad used to turn and I have made things out of wood most of my life. I bought a small lathe for Christmas and spent the festive holiday getting nowhere, until I went to a beginners' night in January, after which I was up and running.

What and who are the greatest influences in your work?

I owe virtually all my progress to Snainton Woodworking Supplies, near Scarborough. I was invited to beginners' nights every Wednesday – free because I bought a lathe from them – and never looked back. Graham and Sue Harker guided me through the key techniques and there isn't much that Rob Thompson doesn't know about timber and turning. Snainton Woodturning Club then enhanced everything with their monthly club nights with top class demonstrators.

If you were to offer one sage piece of advice to someone what would it be?

The best advice I could give any 'would-be' woodturner is get some tuition and guidance, and join a club. You cannot have too much advice – you don't have to act on it all and it will be conflicting at times from different people. You just have to make up your mind about which to take.

What music and which book are you currently into?

I enjoy live music. My wife and I have been to the Perthshire Amber festival for the last few years. Dougie MacLean and Eddi Reader are firm favourites. Closer to home we enjoy Kate Rusby's concerts, especially the Christmas specials. We also fulfilled a lifetime ambition when we saw Leonard Cohen perform live at Leeds Arena a couple of years ago. I haven't read much recently. I like biographies – the last book I read was a biography of Leeds Rugby League great John Holmes.

What is your silliest mistake?

I started stripping down my Nova lathe because it suddenly lost power. I was close to taking off the headstock to return it to my supplier, but then common-sense prevailed – it always pays to start with the most obvious problem, such as the 3-pin plug working loose in the extension socket.

What has been your greatest challenge?

The most challenging, but also most

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